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Ain't That Your GOAT?!

— Stan Culture In Rap Music —

"Stan" is a term in internet and pop culture, that blends "stalker" and "fan", to describe someone who is an extremely obsessive fan of a celebrity. This internet slang term originates from rapper Eminem's hit 2000 track, "Stan".

And because of the term's origins, it's no surprise that stan culture in the rap community frequently mirrors cult-like dynamics, seeing stans treat their favorite rappers like gods.

The dynamic between youtuber DJ Akademiks and rapper Drake is frequently cited as the perfect example of a parasocial relationship in the rap community. For years, DJ Akademiks operated as a mega-fan and mouthpiece for the rapper, eventually earning direct access, contact, and public validation from his favorite rapper, Drizzy Drake.

The phrase "ride-or-die" means to be completely loyal to someone or something no matter what. But the phrase originates from 1950s motorcycle clubs, once describing a biker's literal commitment to ride their Harley-Davidson forever or die trying.

And, just like the OG ride-or-dies, stans in the rap community don't just support their favorite rappers, they become blindly loyal to them. Because of the intensely personal nature of rap music, rap stans don't just consume music; they consume identities, lifestyles, and philosophies.

This level of investment makes any criticism of their favorite rapper feel like a direct attack on themselves.

The Drake versus Kendrick Lamar beef back in 2024 perfectly showcased how rap stans ignore nuance in real time. Across social media the rap community's reaction to the beef saw Drake stans calling Kendrick Lamar's lyrical complexity pretentious and Kendrick Lamar stans comparing Drake's commercial success to McDonald's. The conversation became so polarized that casual listeners found themselves forced to choose a side, not because the music demanded it, but because rap stans controlled the narrative.

The Drake versus Kendrick Lamar beef revealed an uncomfortable truth: rap stans care more about winning petty arguments than engaging with the actual art.

The most insidious aspect of rap stan culture isn't coercion or force, it's community. Cults don't recruit through intimidation; they recruit through acceptance, identity, and a sense of purpose to people searching for connection.

Rap stan culture runs rampant because when someone discovers a rapper whose music resonates with their life, they don't just find an artist; they find a ready-made community of thousands, sometimes millions, of people who share their worldview.

But unlike traditional cults, rap stan communities have no single leader to expose, no single ideology to dismantle, just millions of stans, each convinced they're defending art, when they're actually defending the fandom that they feel defines them.